

Identifying where to place punctuation

In direct speech, a comma is used to separate the text that explains who is speaking from the spoken words. Periods and commas should always go within the quotation marks, while question marks and exclamation points should be left outside unless they are part of the quoted speech. If the end of the direct speech falls at the end of the sentence, only one punctuation mark is needed. When reproducing a quotation, the punctuation and capitalization of the text should be written exactly as it appears in the original text.

The zookeeper continued “Pandas are very agile.” ❌

Quotation marks are placed around direct speech.

The zookeeper continued, “Pandas are very agile.” ✅

This introduces the speech.

A comma is placed before the direct speech.

Periods are always placed before the closing quotation mark.

Can you believe the panda cub “can fit on your hand?” ❌

Quoted material is placed within quotation marks.

Can you believe the panda cub “can fit on your hand”? ✅

The question mark goes outside the quotation marks because it is not part of the quoted material.

Single quotation marks

Single quotation marks are used for quotations within quotations. Any double quotation marks within direct speech or a quotation are changed to single quotation marks to distinguish the words they surround from the rest of the speech or quotation.

- Quotation marks are used to **surround quotations** in the **same way** as they surround **direct speech**.
- In British English, **single quotation marks** are sometimes used in place of double quotation marks for **quoted speech**. Some **US newspapers** also use this style for headlines.

The direct speech is marked by double quotation marks.

SPEAKER

DIRECT SPEECH

The zookeeper said,

“I wouldn’t call pandas ‘cuddly.’”

The zookeeper is quoting someone else’s description of pandas, so the quoted word is within single quotation marks.

REAL WORLD

Air quotes

Air quotes are quotation mark shapes created with a person’s hands when speaking. They serve to highlight unusual words, as quotation marks can in writing, and add a hint of sarcasm to the person’s speech.



Titles of short works

Quotation marks are used for the titles of short works, such as short stories, articles, and song titles. The titles of longer works, such as books and movies, are italicized.

The name of the article is in quotation marks.

The article “Panda Facts” was an eye-opener.